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ABDULRAZAK GURNAH WAS AWARDED THE NOBEL PRIZE IN LITERATURE. *AFTERLIVES*, HIS MOST RECENT NOVEL, HELPS US SEE WHY



The Tanzanian-British author **ABDULRAZAK GURNAH** has written several short stories, essays and acclaimed novels

When the Swedish Academy awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature to Abdulrazak Gurnah last year, they cited his 'dedication to truth'—but this is not truth as an absolute. Instead, as the committee elaborated, 'In Gurnah's literary universe, everything is shifting—memories, names, identities... because his project cannot achieve completion in any definitive sense.'

For even avid readers of Anglophone fiction in India, Gurnah's 'project' is somewhat unknown, though the Tanzanian-British author has written several short stories, essays, and acclaimed novels. *Afterlives*, his most recent book, offers a spectacular entrée into his oeuvre. Set against the backdrop of colonial brutality and repression in eastern Africa (mainly the coastal regions of modern-day Tanzania), the novel follows the intersecting paths of four individuals over the first half of the 20th century. These are people we grow to care about. Their worlds are centred in a nameless town—impossible to locate on a map, but alive in its spaces and characters, the rhythm of its languages, its colliding belief systems.

The novel opens at the turn of the century, in Deutsch-Ostafrika (German East Africa), where the schutztruppe askari, Germany's colonial troops, violently suppress uprising after uprising. The landscape is 'littered with skulls and bones'. World War I is soon to arrive, and the soil

BOOKS

As Happy As Can Be

In his latest novel, Nobel laureate **Wole Soyinka** shows us how Nigeria came to find itself stuck in a cycle of recurring despair

Wole Soyinka, playwright, poet, novelist and activist, has always connected the dots between the colonial presence in Nigeria and the present horrors that plague his nation. The British, as he puts it, go out through the front door and come in again through the back door—though it is not so much the colonisers themselves, but their structures and systems that become inescapable. Soyinka's part in the Nigerian freedom struggle does not blind him to the authoritarianism and deathly religious fanaticism perpetrated by leaders on their own people. In *Chronicles from the Land of the Happiest People on Earth*, he squarely faces the worst of those realities.

The stories of four men frame Soyinka's satire, and we are never sure whether these men correspond to the "Gong of Four" that long ago spoke in their own code and made youthful pacts. Papa Davina engages in a spiritual trafficking that ties together faith, tithes, real estate and capital into an enormously successful multi-denominational church he calls "Chrislam". Indian



WOLE SOYINKA'S WORK SHOWS US FLEETING BUT PERSISTENT GLIMPSES OF THE IDEALS OF YOUNG MEN WHO ONCE THOUGHT TO FASHION A DIFFERENT NATION